

Two flats, R500 apart on paper. R1,330 apart in reality.

Both are within reach of CRC Johannesburg, both need a Wednesday trip to Wits. Once levies, utilities, gym and Uber fares are counted, Petra Nera comes out **R1,330 a month cheaper** — but by a narrower margin than the rents suggest, and for reasons that are not obvious from either listing.

ADVERTISED GAP	ACTUAL MONTHLY GAP	NOT IN SOHO'S RENT	COST PER PERSON
R500	R1,330	R1,400	R665
SoHo R9,500 · Petra Nera R9,000	In Petra Nera's favour — R15,960 a year	Fixed monthly levies the advert never shows	What each of you saves per month at Petra Nera

THE SHORTLIST

Two options, two people

OPTION A SoHo Junction 4 Poplar Ave, Broadacres Park, Sandton 2055 2 bed · 2 bath · 62 m² · 2nd floor, north-facing Available 1 October 2026 R13,773 true monthly Advertised R9,500. Gym, sauna, steam room, pool, business centre, 24/7 guarded security, two parking bays — all on site.	OPTION B Petra Nera 14 Riverbend Rd, Hoogland, Randburg 2188 3 bed · 2 bath Roughly a six-minute walk to CRC R12,443 true monthly Advertised R9,000. No on-site amenities and plainer presentation — but a third bedroom and no church commute at all.
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WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY GOES

A	SoHo Junction	R13,773
B	Petra Nera	R12,443



■ Rent ■ Levies & utilities ■ Gym ■ Uber

Bars are drawn to the same scale. The rent blocks are nearly identical. Everything that separates these two flats sits in the bands to the right of them.

THE CORE NUMBER

What each costs every month

FULL MONTHLY COST — TWO PEOPLE, UBER FOR ALL TRAVEL		
LINE ITEM	A — SOHO JUNCTION	B — PETRA NERA
Rent	R9,500	R9,000
Sanitation confirmed on the SoHo listing	R900	assumed in the R800
Refuse & security levy confirmed on the SoHo listing	R500	assumed in the R800
Electricity verified estimate — see method	R700	R800 combined, as quoted
Water first 6 kL free on Joburg Water	R50	
Housing subtotal	R11,650	R9,800
Gym membership	R0 — on site	R650 Planet Fitness Fourways
Uber — CRC 13 round trips a month	R1,300	R0 — walk
Uber — Wits 4.3 round trips a month	R823	R823
Uber — gym 13 round trips a month	R0	R1,170
Transport subtotal	R2,123	R1,993
Monthly total	R13,773	R12,443
Difference	R1,330 a month · R15,960 a year · R665 each	

HIDDEN COSTS

What neither rent figure includes

Both listings understate. SoHo's omissions are larger and confirmed; Petra Nera's are smaller but unverified — which makes them riskier.

SOHO JUNCTION — CONFIRMED ON THE LISTING		
CHARGE	AMOUNT	NOTE
Sanitation / sewerage	R900	Fixed, not usage-based. You pay it even when away.
Refuse & security levy	R500	Fixed body-corporate charge.
Electricity	~R700	Pre-paid, variable. Lower than usual because the geyser sits on the communal account.
Water	~R50	Pre-paid. Genuinely small — but it cuts off with no grace period when the credit runs out.
Added to the advertised R9,500	R2,150	The advert captures 69% of the true housing cost

THE BIG ONE

Sanitation and refuse alone come to **R1,400 every month — R16,800 a year** that the advert never shows. That is close to two months' rent, invisible at first glance. Both are fixed, so there is no way to reduce them by using less.

SOHO JUNCTION – TO CONFIRM BEFORE SIGNING

ITEM	LIKELY COST	WHY IT MATTERS
01 Deposit	R10,000 unfurnished R20,000 semi-furnished	The deposit <i>doubles</i> on the semi-furnished option. Get the interest-bearing account confirmed in writing — required by the Rental Housing Act.
02 Lease initiation / admin fee	R950 – R1,500 once-off	Petra Nera's equivalent is R2,000, so ask early — this could go either way.
03 Credit & background check	R100 – R500 once-off	Sometimes billed per applicant, so twice for the two of you.
04 Meter activation, access tags, remotes	R300 – R800 once-off	Charged per tag. You need two.
05 Annual escalation	6 – 8%	Year-two rent becomes R10,070–R10,260, and the levies escalate too. Get the percentage into the lease.
06 Special levy	Currently R0	The body corporate can raise one at any time. Ask for the last two AGM minutes and the reserve-fund balance.
07 Contents insurance	R150 – R350 monthly	The landlord insures the building, not your possessions.
08 Early-cancellation penalty	up to ~2 months	The CPA gives you 20 business days' notice, but the landlord may charge a "reasonable" penalty. Get it capped.
09 Fibre installation + router	R0 – R1,800 once-off	Often waived on 12 months. The complex is fibre-ready, not fibre-included.

QUALIFYING GATE – SOHO

R33,000 gross monthly minimum income. A hard criterion. Applying jointly means both of you supply six months of payslips, six months of bank statements, ID, current lease, rental invoice and a clear credit record.

TWO MORE CONSTRAINTS – SOHO

Cats only — no dogs. Second-floor unit.

Available 1 October. If your current lease ends off that date, budget for a gap — storage plus temporary accommodation — or an overlap month at roughly R13,800.

PETRA NERA — TWO THINGS TO PRESS ON

The R2,000 admin fee is high. Market rate for a lease initiation fee is R950–R1,500, so this is roughly R500–R1,000 above normal and it is non-refundable. Worth asking what it covers, and whether it is negotiable.

The R800 utility figure does not add up for a three-bedroom. Water is genuinely tiny — call it R50 — which leaves about R750 for electricity. A three-bed with its own geyser typically runs R1,100–R1,500 a month at current City Power rates. Either the flat has a gas or solar geyser, or the quote excludes something. If sanitation and refuse are billed separately on top as well, this single line could move by **R700–R1,000 a month** — enough to erase most of Petra Nera's advantage.

THE OTHER SIDE OF THE LEDGER

What SoHo's premium buys

Because you are using Uber rather than a car, the on-site gym is worth considerably more here than it would be otherwise — every trip you don't take is a fare you don't pay.

AMENITIES VALUED AGAINST STANDALONE COST	
FACILITY	VALUE IF BOUGHT SEPARATELY
Gym — on site, in the Activity Centre	R650 – R900
Uber fares avoided by the gym being downstairs	R1,170
Sauna and steam room	R200 – R400
Swimming pool , with auto-cleaning equipment	R150 – R300
Business centre — quiet, powered workspace	R300 – R800
24/7 manned guard , CCTV, intercom	R200 – R400
Central geyser , electricity included	R250 – R400
Two parking bays , one covered	R250 – R500
Estimated bundle value	R3,170 – R4,870
What you actually pay for it	R1,330

WORTH SITTING WITH

On paper the SoHo bundle is worth **more than the premium you pay for it**. That only holds if you use it. If the honest answer is “the gym, and the pool occasionally,” the realistic value is closer to R1,800–R2,100 — still ahead of the R1,330 premium, but by much less, and you give up a bedroom to get it.

FITNESS

At Petra Nera the gym costs **R650 membership plus R1,170 in Uber fares — R1,820 a month** to stay fit. At SoHo it is R0 and zero minutes. This is by far the strongest financial argument for SoHo, and it did not exist in the car-based version of this comparison.

WORK & STUDY

The **business centre** is a real asset for Wits work — quiet, powered, seated, on the property. But note that Petra Nera answers this differently and arguably better: with two of you in a three-bed, **the third room becomes a permanent study**, always available, no booking.

SECURITY

24/7 manned guard, CCTV and intercom. This matters most on the Wednesday return from Braamfontein, and it is the one benefit that has no equivalent at Petra Nera until you have seen that building's setup in person.

THE QUIET SAVING

Water heating is typically **30–40% of a household electricity bill**. Having the geyser on the communal account is R250–R400 a month back, and it is why SoHo's electricity estimate is lower than Petra Nera's despite the smaller flat being fully occupied.

TRANSPORT — UBER

The gym trips cancel the church walk

Three days a week to CRC — Monday, Tuesday, Thursday. Wednesday to Wits, with no CRC on campus days. Fares below are the ones you quoted; the gym fare is estimated from the others.

FARES AND MONTHLY UBER SPEND				
TRIP	FARE EACH WAY	ROUND TRIPS PER MONTH	A — SOHO	B — PETRA NERA
Home → CRC	R50 (A)	13	R1,300	R0 — walk
Home → Wits Braamfontein	~R95	4.3	R823	R823
Home → Planet Fitness Fourways	~R45 (est.)	13	R0 gym is on site	R1,170
Monthly Uber spend			R2,123	R1,993

THE COUNTER-INTUITIVE RESULT

Walking to CRC saves **R1,300 a month** — the single biggest line difference anywhere in this comparison. But Ubering to the gym costs **R1,170** of it straight back. Net transport difference: **R130 a month**. Petra Nera’s location advantage is almost entirely spent on getting to a gym that SoHo would have given you for free.

HOW OFTEN YOU GO TO GYM CHANGES THIS

GYM VISITS	B MONTHLY TOTAL	GAP
2× a week	R12,053	R1,720
3× a week	R12,443	R1,330
4× a week	R12,833	R940
6× a week	R13,613	R160

SoHo only draws level at roughly **6.4 gym visits a week** — so on gym use alone it never quite catches up. But the more seriously you train, the smaller the gap gets.

DISTANCES — CONTEXT ONLY

SoHo → CRC	~5 km
SoHo → Wits	~25 km
Petra Nera → CRC	~500 m — 6 min walk
Petra Nera → Wits	~24 km
Petra Nera → gym	~3.5 km

Because you are using Uber, the fares drive the numbers and these distances are indicative only. They are shown to sense-check the fares, not to compute them.

TIME, NOT MONEY

Local travel comes to roughly **6.5 hours a month at SoHo** against **7.3 at Petra Nera** — the CRC walk is short, but thirteen gym round trips are not. Wits is near-identical either way at about seven hours a month. On time, this is a wash.

CASH

Moving in, and the first year

CASH NEEDED TO MOVE IN		
ITEM	A — SOHO JUNCTION	B — PETRA NERA
Deposit refundable	R10,000 R20,000 if semi-furnished	R9,000 confirmed
First month's rent	R9,500	R9,000
Admin / lease initiation fee	~R1,250 to confirm	R2,000 confirmed — above market
Credit check	~R300	included?
Meter activation, access tags	~R500	~R500
Gym joining fee	R0	~R350
Fibre install + router	R0 – R1,800	R0 – R1,800
Moving costs	R3,000 – R6,000	R3,000 – R6,000
Cash needed	R24,550 – R29,350	R23,850 – R28,650

Move-in cash is essentially the same. Petra Nera's lower deposit and rent are almost exactly offset by its R2,000 admin fee and the gym joining fee — a difference of about R700, which is not a deciding factor either way.

YEAR - ONE TOTAL		
	A — SOHO JUNCTION	B — PETRA NERA
Twelve months of running cost	R165,276	R149,316
Non-refundable once-off costs	~R7,450	~R7,750
Year-one cash out	~R172,700	~R157,100
Plus deposit held	R10,000	R9,000
Difference over year one		R15,600 · R7,800 each

What would flip this decision

The R1,330 gap is not robust. Three plausible corrections would close most of it, and two of them turn on the same unverified number.

SENSITIVITY — EACH SCENARIO APPLIED ON ITS OWN			
IF...	B MONTHLY	GAP	VERDICT
Base case — everything as quoted	R12,443	R1,330	Petra Nera clearly ahead
Petra Nera’s electricity is really R1,300 for a three-bed with its own geyser	R12,993	R780	Still ahead, less comfortably
Sanitation and refuse are billed separately at Petra Nera too	R13,443	R330	Effectively a tie
Both of the above	R13,993	−R220	SoHo becomes cheaper
SoHo’s electricity is R900 rather than R700	R12,443	R1,130	Petra Nera still ahead
You go to gym six times a week	R13,613	R160	Effectively a tie

ONE NUMBER DECIDES THIS

Everything hinges on what Petra Nera’s **R800** actually covers. If it is the genuine all-in figure, Petra Nera wins by R1,330 a month. If it excludes sanitation, refuse and a realistic geyser load, **SoHo Junction is the cheaper flat**. Get this in writing before you decide anything else.

The honest ledger on each

OPTION A SoHo Junction — R9,500 2 bed / 2 bath / 62 m²	OPTION B Petra Nera — R9,000 3 bed / 2 bath, 14 Riverbend Rd

IN FAVOUR

- **The gym costs you nothing to reach.**
At Petra Nera staying fit runs R1,820 a month once Uber is counted. This is the strongest financial argument for SoHo
- Sauna, steam room and pool on the same terms — zero travel, zero friction
- Business centre — a quiet powered workspace for Wits work, on the property
- Function room for hosting without needing a big flat
- 24/7 guarded security, CCTV and intercom — real value on the Wednesday return from Braamfontein
- **Two parking bays included**, one covered — worth R250–R500 a month, and useful the moment either of you gets a car
- Central geyser with electricity included — R250–R400 a month back
- North-facing: better light, lower winter heating
- Newer and better presented — nicer to live in, nicer to host in
- Every cost is documented on the listing. You know what you are signing

IN FAVOUR

- **Walking distance to CRC** — R1,300 a month saved, and the single biggest line difference in the whole comparison
- **R1,330 a month cheaper** all-in — R15,960 a year
- **A third bedroom for two people.** A permanent study, always available — which answers SoHo's business centre with something better
- More space, less money
- No transport decision before church. You can be involved in midweek and evening activity without a fare attached to every visit
- Simple utility bill — *if* the R800 holds
- Lower deposit and lower rent
- Available now rather than October, most likely — worth confirming

AGAINST

- **R1,330 a month more — R15,960 a year, R665 each**
- **R1,400 a month of fixed levies sit outside the advertised rent**
- **R1,300 a month in Uber fares to CRC** that Petra Nera simply does not have
- Pre-paid water *and* electricity — no grace period, supply cuts when credit runs out
- **One fewer bedroom.** With two of you, that is the difference between having a study and not
- 62 m² is compact for two people sharing
- Deposit doubles to R20,000 on the semi-furnished option
- R33,000 gross minimum income — a hard gate you both have to clear
- Cats only — no dogs
- The body corporate can raise a special levy at any time
- Only available 1 October — possible gap or overlap month

AGAINST

- **Not attractive** — and this is where you both live and host every day. Over twelve months that is not a rounding error
- **Staying fit costs R1,820 a month** — R650 membership plus R1,170 in Uber fares, plus about 4.3 hours of travel
- **The R800 is unverified and looks low** for a three-bed with its own geyser. This alone could close most of the gap
- **R2,000 admin fee** — roughly R500–R1,000 above market, non-refundable
- No pool, sauna, steam room, business centre or function room
- The gym becomes a decision with a fare attached, every single time. Off-site memberships lapse
- Security arrangements unknown — must be seen and compared against SoHo's 24/7 guard
- Parking allocation unknown
- Walking to CRC after dark needs an honest safety assessment before it counts as a benefit
- Older or less-maintained stock may mean higher niggles-cost — geyser, plumbing, damp

VERDICT

Petra Nera — but the margin is thinner than it looks

Petra Nera is R1,330 a month cheaper, gives the two of you a third room to use as a study, and removes the church commute entirely. On the numbers as quoted, it wins.

But the case is more fragile than the first look suggests. Switching to Uber changed the picture materially: the gym is no longer a minor convenience at SoHo, it is worth **R1,820 a month** — and it cancels almost all of Petra Nera's walking-distance advantage. Meanwhile the R800 utility quote does not survive scrutiny for a three-bedroom flat. Two plausible corrections and SoHo becomes the cheaper option outright.

THREE QUESTIONS DECIDE IT

- Q1 **What does Petra Nera's R800 actually cover?** Get it in writing: sanitation, sewerage, refuse, and what kind of geyser the flat has. This one number is worth R700–R1,000 a month and it is the difference between Petra Nera winning comfortably and SoHo winning outright.
- Q2 **How seriously will you train?** At two gym visits a week Petra Nera is R1,720 ahead. At six it is R160 ahead — a tie. If either of you is training properly, SoHo's gym is not a perk, it is a line item worth nearly two thousand rand.
- Q3 **How much is walking to church worth beyond the fare?** R1,300 a month is the measurable part. The rest is that nothing stands between you and being there — no booking, no fare, no waiting. That is the argument a spreadsheet cannot score, and it is the strongest thing Petra Nera has.

Recommendation: Petra Nera — conditional on the R800 being confirmed in writing as genuinely all-in, seeing the security setup in person, and walking the Riverbend Road route to CRC after dark yourselves. If the utility figure moves by more than about R700, or if you both intend to train five or six days a week, the two options are level and SoHo's amenities, security and presentation become the better buy.

BEFORE SIGNING

Questions to ask each landlord

1. Are the R900 sanitation and R500 refuse/security fixed, or do they escalate annually?
2. What is a realistic monthly electricity spend for a two-bed here, given the central geyser? Ask for a current tenant's actual figure.
3. Are both parking bays included at no extra charge, and allocated in the lease?
4. What is the annual escalation percentage, and does it apply to the levies too?
5. Are any special levies planned? Can we see the last two AGM minutes and the reserve-fund balance?
6. What are the Activity Centre, gym and pool hours, and is there any additional access charge?
7. Is the business centre bookable, and is there a fee?
8. What is the deposit interest arrangement, and which account is it held in?
9. What is the total once-off cost — lease admin, credit checks for two, access tags, meter activation?
10. Does the complex have a generator or inverter for load-shedding, and water tanks for Joburg Water outages?
11. What is the early-cancellation penalty, and can it be capped in writing?
12. Is the R10,000 deposit confirmed for the unfurnished option?

1. **Does the R800 include sanitation, sewerage and refuse — or are those billed separately?**
2. **What kind of geyser does the flat have** — electric, gas or solar? An electric geyser in a three-bed makes R800 unrealistic.
3. Can we see a recent utility bill or statement for the unit?
4. **What does the R2,000 admin fee cover, and is it negotiable?** Market rate is R950–R1,500.
5. What is the annual escalation percentage?
6. What is the security setup — guard, access control, CCTV, perimeter?
7. How many parking bays, and are they covered or allocated?
8. Backup power and water storage during load-shedding and municipal outages?
9. Age and condition of the geyser, plumbing and roof — and who pays for repairs?
10. Will the landlord contribute to repainting or basic cosmetic improvement given the condition?
11. What is the exact walking route and distance to the CRC entrance, and is it lit at night?
12. When is it available, and is the R9,000 held for a 12-month lease?

How the utility figures were checked

WATER — R50 CONFIRMED

Johannesburg Water gives the **first 6 kL a month free** to residential customers, then charges R16.45/kL from 6 to 10 kL. Two people typically use 6–8 kL, so the metered cost really is in the tens of rands. **R50 is right** — the earlier R350 estimate was wrong. Watch only for the demand-management levy, which rose to about R108 a month in July 2026 and may sit on the body-corporate account rather than yours.

ELECTRICITY — R120 IS THE FIXED CHARGE, NOT THE BILL

City Power's 2026/27 prepaid residential tariff runs **R3.06–R4.37 per kWh**, plus roughly R200 a month in fixed charges — a R70 service charge and a **R130 network capacity charge**. That R130 is almost certainly the R120 figure you had in mind. Actual consumption sits on top of it. A two-person flat uses 300–450 kWh a month; strip out the geyser at 30–40% and SoHo lands around **200–280 kWh, or R650–R900**. R700 is used here. Ask the agent for a current tenant's real number — it is the cheapest way to settle this.

ASSUMPTION	VALUE	SOURCE / CHANGE IT IF...
Occupancy	Two people, both flats	Third room at Petra Nera used as a study, not let
Transport mode	Uber for everything	If either of you gets a car, SoHo's two free parking bays start to matter and the gap narrows further
Uber — SoHo to CRC	R50 each way	Your figure
Uber — either flat to Wits	~R95 each way	Your figure — “just under R100”
Uber — Petra Nera to gym	~R45 each way	Estimated from your other fares over ~3.5 km. The one fare not confirmed — worth checking in the app
CRC trips	13 round trips a month	Mon, Tue, Thu × 4.33 weeks
Wits trips	4.3 round trips a month	Wednesdays, no CRC on campus days
Gym visits	3× a week — 13 round trips	See the sensitivity table for 2, 4 and 6
SoHo electricity	R700/month	City Power 2026/27 tariff, geyser excluded. Range R650–R900
SoHo water	R50/month	Johannesburg Water — first 6 kL free
SoHo sanitation & refuse	R900 + R500	Stated on the Property24 listing
Petra Nera utilities	R800/month combined	As quoted — unverified, and the biggest risk in the model
Petra Nera deposit & admin	R9,000 + R2,000	Your figures
Planet Fitness	R650/month	Single-club range is R400–R900; Fourways is a Megacub. Vitality, Multiply and Reality discount up to 75%
Weeks per month	4.33	—
Distances	Indicative only	Road-route estimates from the address pins. Fares drive the model, not kilometres

SOURCES

- Property24 listing — SoHo Junction, Fourways — rent, deposit, sanitation, refuse and security, amenities, income requirement, pet policy, availability
- Johannesburg Water tariffs and the City of Johannesburg approved 2026/27 tariffs — first 6 kL free, R16.45/kL thereafter, demand-management levy
- City Power July 2026 tariffs — R3.34–R4.37/kWh incl. VAT, R70 service charge, R130 network capacity charge
- Planet Fitness Fourways Megacub — cnr Witkoppen Rd & Nerine Dr, The Buzz Shopping Centre

- Gym prices in 2026 — BusinessTech — R400–R900 a month, single club
- CRC Johannesburg — cnr Witkoppen & Riverbend Road, Fourways